

Master of Spices

An unlikely denouement but it does spice up a lively literary broth set in France

By Dilip Bobb

Gallic noses will turn up in collective scorn at this epicurean insult, even if it is fiction. The 100-ft journey of the book's title ends with an immigrant from India being ranked as a three-star Michelin-ranked chef. *Sacré bleu!* What a preposterous idea. A foreigner with a Muslim name creating celebrated dishes in his restaurant in Paris and being elevated to the highest echelons of French haute cuisine? Yet, it is a literary idea that simmers well. The book's recipe revolves around the Haji family from Mumbai who set up

Haji perè literally pitches his tent in the town, opening an Indian restaurant transplanted from Mumbai, complete with blaring Bollywood music and garish posters, just 100 yards from a restaurant run by a famous French chef, Madame Mallory. The raucous Indian restaurant *Maison Mumbai* with its offensive smells and unsophisticated owner pitted against Mallory, master chef and ultimate snob in the heart of the French countryside offers ideal masala for a spicy literary curry. Papa Hasan eventually wins the battle based on his belief that politics in a small provincial town in France are no different from the Bombay he has left:



THE HUNDRED-FOOT JOURNEY
by RICHARD C. MORAIS
HarperCollins
Price: Rs 295
Pages: 177



SAURABH SINGH

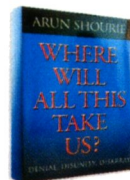
shop in a small, insular, provincial French town called Lumière and the chaotic events that follow (disclosure: HarperCollins India is a joint venture with the INDIA TODAY Group).

It is a strange choice of subject for the author, a senior editor with *Forbes*. He is an American raised in Switzerland who spent many years in the UK and Europe. Yet, his description of Mumbai, of the Haji family and in particular, the patriarch, Abbas Haji, with his sweat-stained armpits, crude habits, larger than life ambitions and persona is remarkably authentic. Much of the credit goes to the late filmmaker and gastronome Ismail Merchant who was a friend of the author. Much of the material for this book are the fruits of that association, or rather, the spices.

Lumière is the backdrop for most of the book.

"both are oiled by the grease of commerce."

The secondary plot is to do with a shortage of staff which forces his son Hasan Haji into the kitchen, where he discovers his true calling and a dormant talent. From there, it's a mere 100 yards (as in the book's title) to Madame Mallory's kitchen and the arcane world of French haute cuisine, fulfilling, in his words; "A Muslim's secret desire to be part of this pig-butcherer underworld." The well-crafted dialogue, the authenticity of setting and cast of characters makes for a bubbly literary broth and though Hasan's elevation to restaurant owner and master chef in Paris is rather abrupt and fast forwards in undue haste, Morais does enough to deserve the literary equivalent of a Michelin star. ■



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